

# Visualization Assignment

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For my assignment I have picked a visualization showing the population percentage of each country represented by a voronoi treemap. Each polygon represents a country, and its area of the polygon represents the country's population. The intent of this visualization is to show relative country population sizes; however, it appears to be targeted at a North American audience. Meirelles discusses visual hierarchies in visualizations. She mentions, "In the art and design fields, we refer to hierarchy of visual elements mostly in relation to emphasis and attention" (Meirelles 19). I will be basing my analysis on the visual hierarchy and emphasis this visualization puts on certain regions.

The visualization initially draws your eyes to China and India. These two countries are the largest by population and therefore, have the biggest amount of whitespace in the visualization. This causes them to grab your attention first when viewing the graphic for the first time. In the graphic, they are separated by a bold black line (used to show continent groupings) that when followed, leads straight to the USA. The outcome of this design is that you initially see the comparison between China and India's populations, then immediately follow the bold black line to the USA.

If the purpose was to compare country sizes, a better approach would be to group countries by size. This visualization does not do this. Countries are grouped by continent first. Within each continent there does not seem to be any sorting based on population. To tie into my previous point about prioritizing relevant countries. Ethiopia is the second biggest country by

population in Africa, yet it gets pushed to the right side away from the USA, shifting focus away from it.

This visualization implicitly implies the relevance of each country viewed from an American's perspective. The countries closer to the vertical centre line have more economic influence and presence in an average American's life, where the countries further to the sides are, for the most part, poorer. This helps to refine my perceived implicit purpose of the graphic: Comparing the USAs population to countries that are relevant to an American viewer.

Although the visualization may not have been initially designed to show the global power imbalance, it has implicitly by using visual hierarchies. Its use of visual cues like bolded lines and physical positions in the graphic imply relevance and implicitly exerts North America's power over other poorer countries. This has helped me to grow my understanding of implicit power, and how it can potentially influence a person—or in this case, a viewer—without them noticing.

## Works Cited

McCandless, David, et al. "India Overtakes China as the World's Most Populous Country."

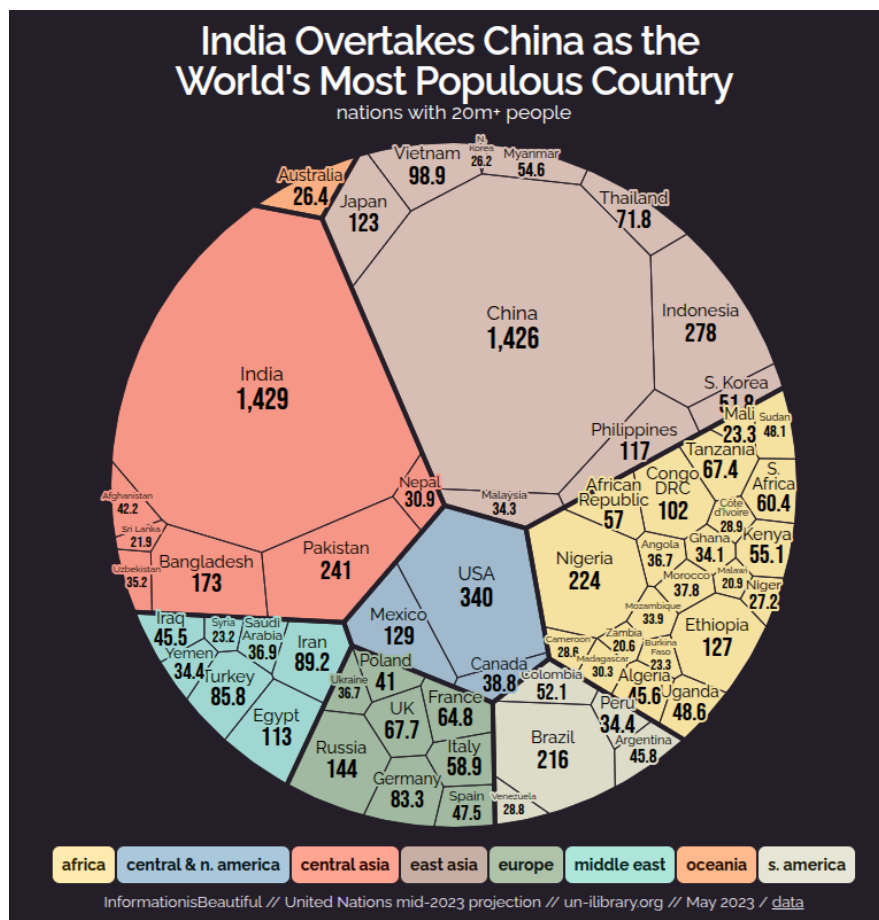
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<https://informationisbeautiful.net/visualizations/world-population/>. Accessed 6 October 2026.

Meirelles, Isabel. "Hierarchical Structures: Trees." *Design for Information: An Introduction to the*

## *Histories, Theories, and Best Practices Behind Effective Information Visualizations,*

Rockport Publishers, 2013, pp. 17-46.



Visualization showing the global population split into countries by David McCandless.

<https://informationisbeautiful.net/visualizations/world-population/>